Extra Exercises 03 – Model Selection & Free Plans

AI Training for Beginners

Self-study training: use AI/LLMs safely in everyday life

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https://github.com/mgunthner/AI-Training

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Extra Exercises 03 – Model Selection & Free Plans

Cheatsheet: `01_cheatsheets/03_model_selection`

Levels: ★ Getting started · ★★ Everyday · ★★★ Challenge **Rule:** Use only invented or anonymized data. All tasks work with any AI service and on a free plan.

Task 1 ★ – What can I choose?

Scenario: You use an AI service but have never paid attention to the model selection.

Task: Look in your service for a model selection or a thinking mode. Note which options you have and how the vendor describes them.

Hint: Some services choose the model automatically or offer no selection on the free plan. In that case, note exactly that.

Task 2 ★ – Small or large?

Scenario: You have six everyday tasks.

Task: Assign each task: small, fast model (S) or larger model / thinking mode (L)? - a) Translate a sentence into English - b) Sort a shopping list by supermarket section - c) Create a study plan for three exams with different dates and limited time - d) Make a paragraph more concise - e) Weigh two kitchen quotes against several criteria - f) Find spelling errors in an email

Hint: Rule of thumb: simple → small, tricky or important → larger.

Task 3 ★★ – Two models, one weekly menu

Scenario: You want to plan a weekly menu and wonder whether a larger model is worth it.

Task: Give the same prompt to two models (or modes, or services):

```
Plan a weekly menu for four people. It should be vegetarian, stick to
↪  a
```

```
limited budget, and make sensible use of leftovers from the previous
↪  day.
Output a table with the dishes and a joint shopping list.
```

Rate both results in a table on: completeness, clarity, speed, plausibility (Does the shopping list match the dishes?).

Hint: Check the results yourself instead of deciding on impression alone.

Task 4 ★★ – Profile of my free plan

Scenario: You want to know what your plan can and cannot do.

Task: Open the vendor's website or the help pages of your service and fill in this note:

Question	My answer
Which models are available to me?	
Are there usage limits? How are they described?	
Which features are included (e.g. web search, file upload, images)?	
How does the vendor handle inputs (storage, training)?	
Date of the note	

Hint: Always record the date. Details change often; the note is only valid for that point in time.

Task 5 ★★★ – My switching rule

Scenario: You don't want to reconsider every time which model to use.

Task: Write a personal rule following this pattern: "I start with …. If …, I switch to …. When …, I additionally verify the result myself." Test it for a week on real tasks and adjust it.

Hint: Also take your usage limit into account. Think about when a larger model is worth it and when it isn't.

Suggested solutions

Task 1: There is no "right" answer. Typical results: a selection of several models, a switch for the thinking mode, or no selection at all because the service decides automatically. What matters is that you know what your service offers.

Task 2: S: a, b, d, f. L: c, e. Reasoning: a, b, d and f are simple transformations or sorting tasks. c and e require weighing several conditions at once. That is the strength of larger models or the thinking mode.

Task 3: Possible observation: The larger model takes more conditions into account (e.g. using up leftovers) and delivers a more consistent shopping list. The small one is faster. Often the small model is already enough. The result depends on the service and on the day. Equal-quality results are a valid conclusion: then the smaller model saves limit.

Task 4: No fixed solution template. Check whether you recorded the date and source and whether you could answer the “inputs and training” item. If you find nothing on that, look in the privacy settings (topic 04).

Task 5: Example: “I start with the small model. If the result is superficial or contradictory, I switch to the larger model or activate the thinking mode. For numbers, dates and legal matters, I always verify the result myself.”